

NEW ZEALAND RESOURCE CENTRE

Occupational Therapy Board of New Zealand Registration Guide

Your complete guide to professional registration in New Zealand — explained in plain English, for internationally qualified occupational therapists.



Welcome to your registration guide

For internationally qualified occupational therapists, registration with the Occupational Therapy Board of New Zealand (OTBNZ) is the essential first step toward practising here — and in most cases it needs to be well underway before you can take up a role.

That order surprises many people. In a lot of countries you secure a job first and sort out the paperwork afterwards. New Zealand works the other way around: the title "occupational therapist" is protected by law, and an employer generally needs to see that you are registrable — or already registered — before progressing your application. Understanding that early shapes everything that follows.

This guide explains the process from beginning to end, built from practical experience supporting internationally qualified healthcare professionals through registration. It focuses on the things that genuinely make a difference: understanding how the Board assesses your qualifications, evidencing your competence correctly through the desktop self-assessment, and avoiding the small mistakes that quietly add weeks to an application.

How to use this guide

Read it once from start to finish to understand the shape of the journey, then keep it nearby and return to each section as you reach it. Think of it as a handbook rather than a leaflet.

An important note

This guide is designed to complement, not replace, the official guidance published by the Occupational Therapy Board of New Zealand. The Board sets the rules and makes all registration decisions. Where there is ever any difference between this guide and the Board's own published requirements, the Board's guidance always takes precedence. Ethicare supports and guides you through the process; we do not make registration decisions on the Board's behalf.

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A quick word before you start

OTBNZ assesses each overseas application individually rather than against a fixed checklist — Board-appointed occupational therapists review your qualifications, and you demonstrate your competence through a written desktop self-assessment. That makes thorough, well-evidenced preparation genuinely valuable, and this guide is built to help you do exactly that.

Understanding the Board

The Occupational Therapy Board of New Zealand (OTBNZ) — Te Poari Whakaora Ngangahau o Aotearoa — is the regulator responsible for the registration and oversight of occupational therapists in New Zealand.

The Board operates under the **Health Practitioners Competence Assurance Act 2003**, the legislation that governs regulated health professions across New Zealand. Its core purpose is to protect the public by ensuring that everyone practising as an occupational therapist is suitably qualified, competent and of good character.

Why registration is required

In New Zealand, the title "occupational therapist" is protected by law. You cannot lawfully use the title or practise — including by telehealth from overseas — without being registered with the Board and holding a current practising certificate. Practising, or claiming the title, while unregistered is an offence under section 7 of the Act.

An individual assessment, not a fixed pathway

This is the single most important thing to understand about OTBNZ. Overseas applications are assessed on their individual merits — for fitness, equivalence of qualifications, and competence — by Board-appointed occupational therapists. The quality and completeness of the evidence you provide directly shapes the outcome.

Registration vs. the practising certificate

Two related but separate things. **Registration** confirms you have met the standard to practise. The **practising certificate** is what then permits you to actually work, and it must be renewed each year (the APC year runs 1 April to 31 March). You must hold a current practising certificate at all times while practising — even when employed under a different job title or in a voluntary role.

Qualification & competence assessment



Registration in the general scope



Practising certificate



Two pathways: standard and abridged

Which pathway you use depends on where you trained and where you're registered. For Ethicare's UK-based candidates, the abridged pathway is often the relevant one — so understand it early.

The abridged pathway

If you obtained your occupational therapy qualification in the **UK, Ireland, Canada or South Africa** and are currently registered in one of those countries, you may apply using an **abridged pathway** that recognises the similarities in regulation and practice. Your qualification must be from an education facility accredited by the **World Federation of Occupational Therapists (WFOT)**.

The abridged pathway streamlines the evidence required — for example, it asks for your qualification certificate and academic transcript rather than the full detailed syllabus — but it does not lower the standard you must meet, and the cultural-competence and good-character requirements still apply.

The standard overseas pathway

If you trained elsewhere, you apply via the standard overseas pathway. The core requirements are the same, with more detailed scrutiny of your course content so the Board can judge equivalence — including your qualification certificate, full academic transcript, and a detailed course description or syllabus.

Trans-Tasman applicants

If you are currently registered as an occupational therapist with Ahpra in Australia, you register in New Zealand under the **Trans-Tasman Mutual Recognition Act 1997** rather than the overseas-trained route — a different and generally faster process.

Not sure which applies?

This is one of the first things we'll confirm with you. Choosing the right pathway from the outset avoids re-work later and makes the document-gathering far simpler.

How the Board assesses your qualifications

Because the Board assesses each application individually, it helps enormously to know exactly what its appointed assessors are looking for.

What the Board looks for

- A relevant occupational therapy qualification, assessed as equivalent to a New Zealand qualification by Board-appointed occupational therapists.
- For the abridged pathway, a qualification from a **WFOT-accredited** programme in the UK, Ireland or Canada, and current registration in that country.
- Evidence of your current registration and good standing with the authority where you trained and practise.
- That you are of good character and a "fit" person to practise — confirmed through references and a criminal-history check.
- That you can communicate effectively in English (see Section 07).

Primary source verification

The Board may require **primary source verification** of your identity and qualifications — confirming them directly with the issuing institution. If so, this is arranged at your own cost, and you'll be advised after your application is assessed. Building this possibility into your timeline avoids surprises.

Present it like a professional portfolio

How your application looks matters more than people expect. Clean, high-resolution colour scans; documents certified correctly the first time; consistent naming. A well-organised application is assessed more smoothly than a disorganised one containing exactly the same facts.

Demonstrating your competence

Beyond your qualifications, OTBNZ asks overseas applicants to actively demonstrate competence against its national standards. Getting this right is the part international applicants most often underestimate.

Occupational therapists in New Zealand must demonstrate their ability to meet the Board's **Competencies for Registration and Continuing Practice**. For overseas applicants, this is shown through three connected steps, completed through your applicant portal after your initial application:

- **A written desktop competence self-assessment** — the centrepiece. You evidence, against each competency, how your practice meets the New Zealand standard. Vague, general statements rarely satisfy the assessors; specific examples from your practice carry far more weight.
- **Your current CV / résumé** detailing your work history, with any significant gaps (travel, family leave) briefly explained.
- **The Ngā Paerewa Te Tiriti eLearning course** — the Board's cultural-competence requirement (covered in Section 08).

On the standard pathway, at least one of your referees — an occupational therapist who has worked with you — is asked to **view your competence self-assessment and confirm it accurately represents your practice**. Choose that referee with care.

Top tip — draft your self-assessment early

You can begin mapping your experience to the New Zealand competencies before you even submit, using the Board's published competencies document. Arriving at the portal with your examples already drafted turns the most demanding step into a straightforward one.

Eligibility & documents

Alongside your qualification and competence evidence, the Board needs a set of supporting documents. Each exists for a reason — understanding why makes them easier to satisfy.

Qualification evidence

Why: your degree is the foundation of registration, and the Board makes its own assessment of it. **What to provide:** certified copies of your occupational therapy qualification certificate and academic transcript; on the standard pathway, also a detailed course description / syllabus.

Identity

Why: to confirm who you are and link your records. **What to provide:** two forms of identity documentation (one with a photograph), certified, plus evidence of any name change. Non-English documents need a certified translation alongside a certified copy of the original.

Previous registration

Why: to confirm you're registered and in good standing where you practise. **What to provide:** a certificate of good standing from every authority you're currently or were previously registered with, plus details of any disciplinary action taken or pending.

Hard copies still matter

Several documents — your certified ID, qualification certificate, transcript, certificates of good standing and criminal-history check — must also be sent to the Board in **hard copy** by post or courier, not only uploaded. Plan the postage time into your schedule.

References & criminal history

Two requirements with precise rules that are easy to get slightly wrong — and a small error means starting that piece again. Here's exactly what the Board expects.

References

You must supply **three referees** willing to provide a reference. Each should be over 18, have known you for more than 12 months, not be a relative, and not live at your address. Crucially:

- **At least one must be an occupational therapist** with whom you have worked for more than six months in the last two years.
- On the standard pathway, that occupational therapist referee is also asked to review your competence self-assessment and confirm it reflects your practice.

Criminal history

You must declare any convictions, and provide a criminal-conviction check for your country of current registration and **any other country you have lived in for more than six months in the last ten years**. A New Zealand criminal-history check is arranged for you during processing (unless you've never been to NZ).

A conviction isn't an automatic bar

If you have a conviction, it does not necessarily prevent registration — the Board considers each on a case-by-case basis. The right approach is full, honest disclosure with an explanatory note. Non-disclosure is treated far more seriously than most underlying matters.

English language requirements

English-language evidence exists for one reason: safe, precise communication with clients and colleagues. The Board's rule here is specific.

When you need to provide a test

You must provide English evidence if English is not your first language. You are generally exempt if your education meets one of the Board's recognised-country routes — broadly, if you completed your occupational therapy qualification (and the relevant schooling) taught and assessed in English in a **recognised country**: New Zealand, Australia, Canada, the Republic of Ireland, South Africa or the United Kingdom. Speakers of te reo Māori or NZ Sign Language as a first language are exempt.

The accepted tests and scores

Where a test is required, OTBNZ accepts **two** options — you may choose either:

- **OET** (Occupational English Test), Occupational Therapy version — a minimum grade **B** in each of the four components (listening, reading, writing, speaking).
- **IELTS Academic** — at least **7.0 in each band**.

You may combine ("club") results across more than one sitting, provided the required standard is achieved within 12 months of your first test. Results must be no older than **24 months** when submitted.

Note — a more flexible bar than some professions

OT's IELTS requirement (7.0 in each band) is a touch lower than the higher psychology threshold, and OET is fully accepted as an alternative. If you narrowly miss on one test, the clubbing rule may still get you there — but mind the 12-month and 24-month windows.

Cultural competence & the recertification programme

Two areas unique to practising in New Zealand. Understanding them early turns potential worries into straightforward, even rewarding, steps.

Ngā Paerewa Te Tiriti — cultural competence

Practising in Aotearoa New Zealand reflects the world views of both partners to **te Tiriti o Waitangi** (the Treaty of Waitangi). All applicants complete the Board's **Ngā Paerewa Te Tiriti eLearning course**, an approved online cultural-competence course accessed via Ko Awhatea LEARN. You request your account once the Board has confirmed your application number has been updated to your registration number.

The Recertification Programme

Here's something important to anticipate. Occupational therapists who are **new to practice in Aotearoa New Zealand** — which includes overseas-qualified registrants — complete the Board's **Recertification Programme** when they first practise here. For overseas-qualified practitioners this means **fortnightly supervision** and completion of **Te Rito**.

This is not a mark against you. Its express intent is to ensure you begin practice with sufficient support — for your benefit and for the protection of the public — and to give the Board assurance of competence before you practise independently. (Trans-Tasman applicants are not required to participate.)

A genuine head start

Cultural competence is the step you can most easily begin thinking about today. Engaging with it early both smooths your entry and gives you a meaningful introduction to the healthcare culture you'll be joining.

Applying & what happens next

Once your evidence is assembled, the application itself is methodical. Here's the process and a realistic sense of timing.

1

Confirm your pathway

Standard overseas, abridged (UK/Ireland/Canada/South Africa), or Trans-Tasman.

2

Gather your documents

Certified qualification, transcript (and syllabus on the standard pathway), ID, certificates of good standing, criminal-history checks, and English results if required.

3

Submit your initial application & fee

Through the OTBNZ applicant portal (MyOTBNZ), with the application fee.

4

Complete the portal steps

Desktop competence self-assessment, nominate your referees, upload your CV, and begin Ngā Paerewa Te Tiriti. Your application isn't processed until these are provided.

5

Send hard copies

Post or courier the documents the Board requires in physical form.

6

Assessment & registration

Board-appointed OTs assess your application; once registered, apply for your practising certificate before you can work.

How long it takes

Allow ample time. OTBNZ advises applications may take **up to six weeks to process** once all information, payment and printed documents are received — so the bigger variable is usually how quickly you assemble complete, correctly certified evidence, not the Board's processing itself.

A note on fees

We deliberately treat fees as figures to confirm at the time, because the Board reviews them periodically — but here is the current shape of what's payable.

- **Registration (overseas qualified):** NZD \$1,265 (incl. GST) at the time of writing.
- **Practising certificate:** NZD \$588 (incl. GST) for up to 12 months, or NZD \$190 for up to 3 months.
- **Criminal-history checks** and any **primary source verification** are additional and paid to the relevant providers.

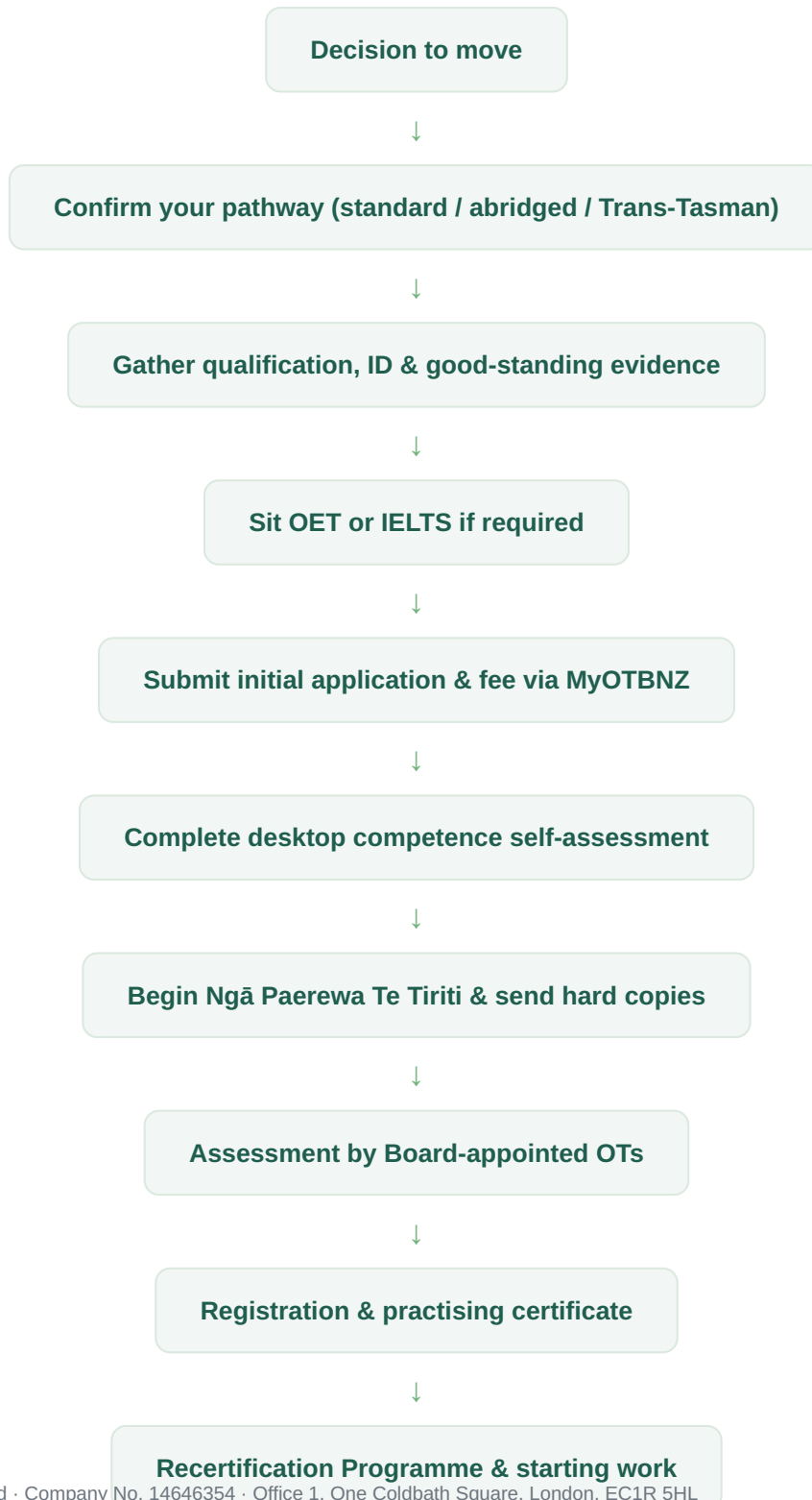
Always confirm the current figures on the Board's official fees page before you budget or pay — we're happy to point you to it.

Worth knowing

You can apply for your practising certificate at the same time as your registration through the portal. As a newly registered overseas practitioner you'll also be entering the Recertification Programme, so factor supervision arrangements into your first year's planning.

Your registration journey

From first decision to first day at work — here is the whole journey on a single page. Keep it nearby; it's the map you'll return to throughout.



Common mistakes to avoid

Almost every avoidable delay traces back to one of the issues below. Read this as a pre-flight checklist.

⚠ **Thin competence self-assessment**

The biggest one. General statements instead of specific, evidenced examples mapped to each New Zealand competency.

⚠ **Wrong pathway**

Using the standard route when you qualify for the abridged one (or vice versa). Confirm your pathway first.

⚠ **No suitable OT referee**

Missing the occupational-therapist referee who has worked with you for 6+ months in the last 2 years.

⚠ **Certification slips**

Uncertified copies, missing translations, or forgetting that several documents must also go by post in hard copy.

⚠ **English results expired**

OET below grade B / IELTS below 7.0 in a band, or results older than 24 months at submission.

✓ **The fix for all of these**

Confirm your pathway, draft the self-assessment early, line up the right referees, and have everything reviewed before you submit.

Frequently asked questions

Is there a faster route for UK-trained therapists?

Often, yes. If you qualified in the UK (or Ireland, Canada, South Africa) from a WFOT-accredited programme and are currently registered there, the abridged pathway recognises the close similarity in regulation and streamlines the evidence required — though the standard and the cultural-competence requirement still apply.

Do I need IELTS, or will OET do?

Either is accepted where a test is required: OET at grade B in each component, or IELTS Academic at 7.0 in each band. You only need a test if English isn't your first language and your training doesn't meet the recognised-country exemption.

What is the desktop competence self-assessment?

A written assessment, completed in your applicant portal, in which you evidence how your practice meets each of the Board's competencies. It's the core of an overseas application — prepare specific examples rather than general statements.

I'm registered in Australia — does that help?

Yes. If you hold current Ahpra registration you transfer under Trans-Tasman Mutual Recognition rather than the overseas-trained route — a different and generally quicker process.

What is the Recertification Programme?

A support programme for therapists new to practice in New Zealand. As an overseas-qualified registrant you'll have fortnightly supervision and complete Te Rito — designed to support you into safe independent practice, not to penalise you.

Can Ethicare review my application?

Yes. We can review your evidence — particularly your competence self-assessment and pathway choice — against what the Board looks for, and flag likely issues while they're still easy to fix. The registration decision always rests with the Board.

HOW ETHICARE WILL SUPPORT YOU

You don't have to navigate this alone

If you choose to partner with Ethicare, we'll support you from first enquiry through registration to relocation and your first day at work — with a single point of contact, honest guidance, and help at every stage. We support and guide you through the process; the registration decision always rests with the Occupational Therapy Board of New Zealand.

READY TO BEGIN?

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